

founded another line of alternative tradition that was claimed to be older than—and utterly superior to—Christian revelation. The result was a full-blown polytheistic model of religion that Plethon wanted to introduce. Presumably due to his admiration of the Chaldaean Oracles, Plethon did not refer to Hermes Trismegistus and the Graeco-Egyptian writings attributed to him, nor to the Jewish kabbalah that had already taken shape.<sup>12</sup>

The combination of Neoplatonism, Hermeticism, and *prisca theologia* that became so influential in Renaissance esotericism was a result of the reintroduction of the Corpus Hermeticum into western European culture.<sup>13</sup> Marsilio Ficino (1433–1499) interrupted his translation of the Platonic writings when Cosimo de' Medici asked him to translate the manuscripts of the Corpus Hermeticum that were rediscovered in 1463 and brought to Cosimo. This was only logical insofar as some scholars argued that Hermes Trismegistus was older than Plato and perhaps even older than Moses, thus making accessible the ancient ultimate knowledge of mankind.<sup>14</sup> Ficino's translation was printed in 1471 under the title *Book of the Power and Wisdom of God (Liber de potestate et sapientia Dei)* and became known as *Pimander*, referring to the corpus' first tractate. Thanks to the printing press this translation was published 25 times until 1641. Renaissance Europe thus discovered the *philosophia perennis*, the “eternal philosophy,” as a common denominator of Egyptian, Greek, Jewish, and Christian religion.

### *Genealogies of Wisdom*

Due to the fact that scholars and philosophers in the fifteenth century gained access to texts that stemmed from outside the biblical revelation and might perhaps even be older than those of Jewish and Christian tradition, the question arose how these alternative pieces of knowledge were related to the revelations of the scriptural religions.<sup>15</sup>

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he concludes that “the reception of Zoroaster thus becomes an act of auto-identification,” a self-identification that was followed by many Christian authors.

<sup>12</sup> See Woodhouse, *George Gemistos Plethon*, 59–61.

<sup>13</sup> See von Stuckrad, *Western Esotericism*, 53–56.

<sup>14</sup> On the humanist debate about the age of the Hermetic writings see Mulsow (ed.), *Ende des Hermetismus*.

<sup>15</sup> This process was further enhanced due to the advent of printing; see Eisenstein, *Printing Press as an Agent of Change*.

The answers to this question, diverse as they were, lead us right into the inter-religious tensions of the time, because it makes a big difference whether one's own tradition can claim a greater age and hence a closer relation to the 'original truth,' or not.

Particularly interesting is the comparison between Christian and Jewish claims of tradition, as will be demonstrated later. At this point, reference must be made to the different solutions Christian authors found for the theological problem of the existence of conflicting ways of revelation, or, in the useful—though admittedly simplifying and idealtypical—definition of Moshe Idel, for the *unilinear* and *multilinear* theories of *prisca theologia*. While the unilinear model rejects the assumption that ultimate knowledge can flow from different sources (i.e. from 'pagan' authorities), the multilinear model reckons with the possibility of several sources of revelation that have to be incorporated in a Christian framework. Principally, early modern Christians applied two different solutions to integrate non-Christian sources:

[T]he first contends that they agree with Christian theology because they were influenced by a primeval tradition which included or at least adumbrated the tenets of Christianity; the alternative argues that the affinity between these two bodies of thought has no historical explanation but is the result of a revelation or a series of revelations imparted separately to both pagan and monotheistic spiritual leaders.<sup>16</sup>

The unilinear model was dominant in Christian circles before the fifteenth century and remained so in Jewish circles until the seventeenth century, when it was more and more challenged. Some followed the line of Suhrawardī, Plethon, and others, and argued that there was an independent line of tradition that was even superior to scriptural revelation. But most Christian scholars were reluctant to present the *prisca theologia* in such a radical way. Marsilio Ficino in particular struggled with the implications of multilinear historiographical models and tried to combine these with the Christian tradition. The *one* truth could, after all, be revealed in quite different ways. Inspired by Plethon, Ficino nevertheless presented a line of authorities in which Mosaic sources do not occur: Zoroaster, Hermes Trismegistus, Orpheus, Aglaophamus, Pythagoras, Plato. In his *Philebus Commentary* Ficino explained:

<sup>16</sup> Idel, "Prisca Theologia in Marsilio Ficino and in Some Jewish Treatments," 138–139.

[T]he ancient theologians [*prisci theologii*] [...], since they brought themselves as near as possible to God's ray by releasing their souls, and since they examined by the light of that ray all things by uniting and dividing through the one and the many, they too were made to participate in the truth [*veritatis compotes effecti sunt*].<sup>17</sup>

This explanation refers to the Neoplatonic theurgic traditions of late antiquity that were formulated in the Chaldaean Oracles. The wise men of antiquity—and in their succession the wise men of Ficino's time—could get in touch with the divine sphere through the ascent of their souls. In addition, those who want “to reach the truth [...] must prepare themselves especially by purity of soul for the flowing in of the divine splendour [*ad divini splendoris influxum*].”<sup>18</sup> Both the Neoplatonic sefirot symbolism<sup>19</sup> and the Gnostic self-empowerment of the understanding individual are a characteristic of this line of interpretation. In his *Theologia Platonica* Ficino clearly attests to this ‘pagan’ chain of revelation. In other writings, however, Ficino offered a different explanation: In his apologia for Christian religion, *De Christiana religione*, he acknowledged the influence of certain biblical figures on the *prisca theologia*. Because *Theologia Platonica* and *De Christiana religione* were written in the same period of Ficino's career, the discrepancy between those two interpretations seem to convey his opinion that the pagan theology is not necessarily superior to Christian theology but independent of it.

Giovanni Pico della Mirandola (1463–1494) shared this opinion.<sup>20</sup> In his oration usually referred to as “On the Dignity of Man” (*Oratio de hominis dignitate*)<sup>21</sup> he names Orpheus as the first source of philosophical-theological wisdom, which was carried on to Pythagoras and

<sup>17</sup> Ficino, *The Philebus Commentary*, 246.

<sup>18</sup> *Ibid.*, 246 and 248.

<sup>19</sup> Note that *splendor* is the Latin name of Zohar.

<sup>20</sup> See Trinkaus, *In Our Image and Likeness*, 759–760; Farmer, *Syncretism in the West*, 61–62.

<sup>21</sup> The lecture's title “On the Dignity of Man” is by no means the originally intended one. “Pico's original title, if he had one, was something on the order of *Oratio ad laudes philosophiae* (Oration in Praise of Philosophy). The traditional title *Oratio de hominis dignitate* first appeared ten years after Pico's death in a corrupt German reprint of his collected works” (Farmer, *Syncretism in the West*, 2 note 4). In fact, the title “On the Dignity of Man” is part of a myth-making that the figure of Pico has undergone to end up as a ‘precursor of modernity’; see Craven, *Giovanni Pico della Mirandola, Symbol of His Age*; von Stuckrad, “Christian Kabbalah and Anti-Jewish Polemics.”